

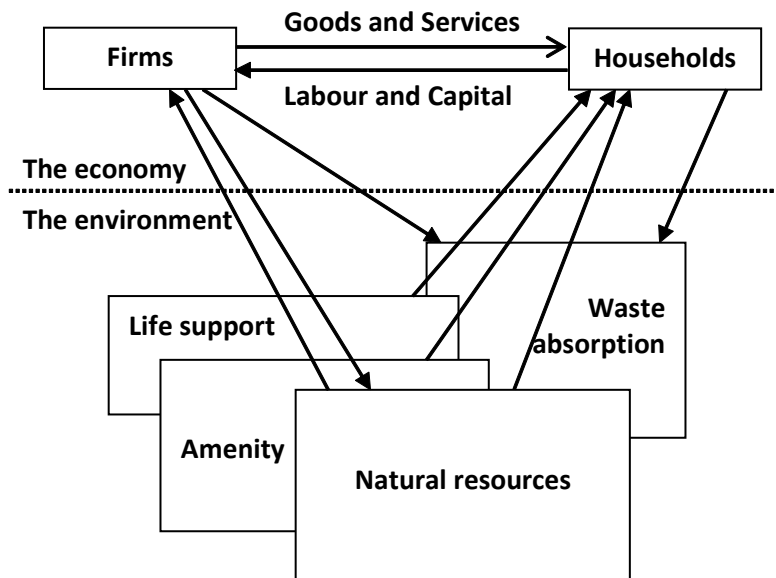


Fig. 4.3

Man's desire for joy and comfort has led him to exploit nature's free goods to the extent of reducing its natural capacities for self-stabilisation. As countries industrialise, they increase their global footprint, which is the pressure they put on the Earth's resources. The footprints of Europe and Japan are about 4.7 global hectares per person, and the USA's is 9.7. India's footprint at present is 0.8 and China's has reached 1.6. Mankind's overall global footprint, which was about 60 per cent of the global biocapacity in the 1960s, has already reached 130 per cent. This gets reflected in growing environmental problems. Environmental problems centre on human activities resulting in pollution of the atmosphere, oceans, and land. These range from the global (greenhouse warming and ozone depletion) to the regional (acid rain and desertification), national (deforestation) and local (soil erosion, contamination of freshwater resources and urban pollution). The relevance of such concerns and the priority attached to each varies between the developing and developed countries.

4.9.1 Environmental Protection in India

Rapid growth has become an obsession with decision makers. Growth is important for the resources it generates, but the welfare of the Indians at whom this growth is being targeted also depends on the quality and integrity of their living environment.

Rapid growth means more mega-projects for infrastructure, mining and manufacturing, and a rapid expansion of urban areas. All large projects involving the exploitation and use of natural resources and urban expansion have environmental consequences which may involve one or more of the following:

- large-scale land use changes often in ecologically sensitive areas;
- displacement of a large number of people from their homes and livelihood sources;
- extensive interventions in natural hydrological regimes;
- disruption of local biotic regimes;

- loss of forest cover, especially owing to mining projects since a very large proportion of the unexploited mineral wealth of India, including coal, lies in forest land; and
- a substantial increase in the air and water pollution load which may be of local, regional, national, or even global concern.

The environmental consequences of rapid urbanisation will become a growing concern. Vehicle ownership is expected to go up by a factor of seven. But with higher vehicle efficiency standards, more public transport in cities and a shift of freight traffic to rail and coastal shipping, growth in energy consumption for transport and the consequential environmental impact may go up by about five times. The requirements of the growing urban population for living and working space, water and waste disposal will have environmental consequences that will have to be managed. Rural-urban conflicts for scarce water and landfill sites for solid waste disposal will arise.

For example, used paper cups thrown outside juice and coffee shops (indicators of rising incomes) could be behind the disappearing population of honeybees that pollinate 80 per cent of all crops. The same is true of the use of plastic in our daily lives, which is finding its way into our food chains, plant and animal based. As World Wildlife Fund Study shows that India is already using 50 per cent more ecological resources each year than can be replenished by nature.

India is ranked a disappointing 101st out of 146 countries for which the Environmental Sustainability Index (ESI) was prepared in early 2005 (The most sustainable country is Finland and the least sustainable is North Korea). The ESI is based on 21 indicators and 76 measurements, including natural resource endowments, past and present pollution levels, and policy efforts. Another waking reminder comes from the Environmental Performance Index 2012 which has placed India at 125th place.

State-wise, the best performing state in India in terms of the ESI is Manipur, followed by Jammu and Kashmir and Tripura. All these states are sustaining their stocks of natural resources. They face less stress on their environmental systems and are exerting lower impacts on environment and health. The lowest ranking states are Gujarat, Punjab and Haryana. These states have diminished stocks of natural resources, especially in terms of air and water quality. They also score low on land use pattern.

Environmental degradation and diseases are responsible for 23 per cent of child mortality, according to a World Bank report. Moreover, the costs of environmental damage are equivalent to 5.7 per cent of the country GDP (in 2009). However, the report says, India can make green growth a reality by putting in place strategies to reduce the damage at a minimal cost of 0.02 per cent to 0.04 per cent of its average annual GDP growth rate.

In short, the present mode of development is wholly unsustainable. The clash between growth imperatives and the environment will become sharper. Therefore, a decision-making framework that anticipates this and puts in place a mechanism that reconciles growth, land acquisition and environmental protection is good for growth, social justice and the environment. The key lies in five elements:

- i) full provision of data and information on project design and impact;

- ii) stakeholder engagement from an early stage, where necessary in public hearings;
- iii) negotiated solutions in which people's rights are affected;
- iv) generous compensation, relief, and rehabilitation assistance; and
- v) careful monitoring by an independent watchdog.

4.9.2 National Environment Policy, 2006 (NEP)

The NEP 2006 is being described as a statement of India's commitment to making a positive contribution to international efforts.

The NEP builds on the earlier policies, like the National Forest Policy, 1988, National Conservation Strategy and Policy Statement on Environment and Development, 1992, National Agricultural Policy, 2000, National Population Policy, 2000, and National Water Policy, 2012.

Its major features are as follows:

- i) The dominant theme of the policy is to ensure that the livelihood of people dependent on forest products is secured through conservation.
- ii) It focuses on conservation of critical environmental resources, livelihood security for the poor, integration of environmental concerns in economic and social development and judicious use of the resources.
- iii) To achieve sustainable development, environmental protection shall constitute an integral part of the development process and cannot be considered in isolation from it.
- iv) Environmental Impact Assessment will continue to be the principal methodology for appraisal and review of new projects.
- v) The assessment processes are being revised. Under the new arrangement, there will be significant devolution of powers to the State/Union Territory level.
- vi) It also seeks to revisit the Coastal Regulation Zone notifications to make the approach to coastal environmental regulation more holistic and, thereby, ensure protection to coastal ecological systems, waters, and the vulnerability of some coastal areas to extreme natural events and potential sea level rise.
- vii) Involvement of Panchayati Raj Institutions and urban local bodies has been highlighted.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) Examine the relationship between economic development and environment.

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